holder disenfranchisement — a referendum did not take place prior to the 2015 elections. Attempts to bring about constitutional changes included a parliamentary commission 2013/2014, an NLD signature campaign in 2014, some high-level talks between leaders since 2014, and a vote for selected constitutional amendments in parliament in 2015, which did not change any of the constitutional conditions disputed by the majority of the opposition at that time. The obstacles to changing the Constitution will likely see much debate over the tenure of the NLD government. It remains to be seen to what extent these debates will also take place outside the legislature, to which the NLD brings electoral legitimacy.

The partial NCA, which has now become President Thein Sein's legacy, established the idea of a structured political dialogue. Quite remarkably, given the major electoral process taking place at the same time, the government and EAG signatories followed a rigid three-month time frame to establish the structures foreseen in the NCA, including the Joint Monitoring Committee (JMC), and the Union Political Dialogue Joint Committee (UPDJC). The UPDJC led to the first Union Peace Conference held in Naypyitaw between 12 and 17 January 2016. Aung San Suu Kyi had not attended the NCA signing ceremony, and no NLD representative signed the document. Despite its initial scepticism about the outcomes of the USDP- and Tatmadaw-led peace process (and about the MPC as the vehicle to facilitate the negotiations), the NLD joined the UPDJC drafting committee after the elections, and Suu Kyi spoke at the opening of the Union Peace Conference alongside the president, the commander-in-chief, and senior EAG leaders. If and how the NLD will use the nascent peace and political dialogue structures — which could include constitutional reform — is not yet apparent.[25] Of course, the electoral process could not bring about constitutional change by itself, and how the core disputed elements will be resolved, if at all, remains to be seen.

CONCLUSION

Despite considerable fears, the 2015 elections were not marred by electoral violence. These fears were fed by the long-term armed conflict between the Tatmadaw and EAGs and escalation of fighting with unusual ferocity during the electoral period; the recent history of inter-communal violence in Rakhine State and beyond, with anti-Muslim rhetoric becoming a